



UK Independence Party Wales

Plaid Annibyniaeth y DU Cymru

Manifesto: Welsh Assembly Election, 3 May 2007

ABOLISH THE ASSEMBLY & LEAVE THE EU

Government in Wales is becoming more and more remote from the electorate. Local councils do what they are told by Cardiff and London and our laws, which should be made by our elected British government, mostly come from Brussels.

Unlike all the old political parties, the UK Independence Party believes in real democracy at all levels. We want Britain out of the European Union so we can govern ourselves, and we want re-empowered local authorities. And, while we respect the Welsh identity, we also believe in preserving the United Kingdom – the nations of the UK work better together than they would apart.

There is no place in this scheme for the Welsh Assembly – an additional layer of government which is soon to acquire more powers. Indeed, devolved government in Wales makes little sense, particularly while Britain remains in the EU.

Wales does not need an Assembly: The Assembly must go.

Key policies

1. Sack the 60 members of the Welsh Assembly and sell their Cardiff building.

Wales has 40 members of the British parliament, 60 Assembly members, 4 Members of the European Parliament and hundreds of Councillors. We don't need all these politicians.

Only 25.3% of Welsh people voted to create the increasingly unpopular Welsh Assembly. UKIP believes that the Assembly is a waste of space and money and its business can be covered by the elected Welsh MPs.

Our policy is to have the British parliament meet for three weeks out of four to debate law that applies to the whole of Britain. Then, in the fourth week, the 40 Welsh MPs come home to attend to Welsh business in a new *Welsh National Council* – with the Scots doing similarly and English MPs staying to debate law that only applies to England. The 60 Welsh Assembly members would be redundant.

The Welsh National Council would meet at different venues in all parts of Wales, so North, East and West Wales are covered too. There would no longer be a Welsh Secretary of State and Welsh MPs would elect a First Minister from their own number.

Wales needs UKIP members of the Assembly who will campaign vigorously for its abolition – and they will be pleased to lose their Assembly jobs when this occurs.

2. Restore local democracy, with direct local votes and more local control over finances.

Today, local councils rely on government funding and obey government orders rather than looking after the interests of their local communities. It's no wonder that so few people turn out to vote at local elections. UKIP believes in restoring local democracy and freeing local government from central government interference.

First, we would provide for local referendums on any major local issue. Once a petitioner obtains enough signatures from local voters calling for a referendum on a subject of their choosing, a referendum must be held and its result would be binding.

Second, we would give local councils much greater control over their finances by letting them keep local business rates. This would enable them to assist small businesses with fairer business rates that reflect local conditions and the extra costs of operating in rural areas.

Finally, local authorities must be made more accountable to the voters by staging more open meetings and adopting more visible decision-making processes. Cabinet style local government must go.

3. Restore the UK's independence by leaving the European Union

The UK pays the European Union £39 million a day. In return, the EU controls farming and fishing, it restricts our trade with the rest of the world, it showers us with thousands of regulations and it is taking over most of the functions of national governments,

There is little point of having an elected British government, let alone a Welsh Assembly, when most laws come from Brussels.

UKIP policy is to take Britain out of the EU so we can trade freely with the rest of the world as well as the EU, just as independent Norway and Switzerland do now. We [would] can also start to unwind all those thousands of EU regulations and directives that interfere with our lives and destroy our businesses,

Return control to our own people. Make our own decisions again instead of being ruled by Brussels bureaucrats

Other policy priorities

Education

There is too much interference from central government in the running of our schools and universities. Teachers have to put paperwork and performance targets above the needs of pupils. Standards have collapsed and many of our children leave school unable to read and write.

UKIP Wales says

- Independence for schools and colleges over teaching, examinations and discipline.
- Return to selective education and grammar schools, but with fair treatment for all schools and selection on merit rather than postcode.
- Introduce vouchers to help parents to choose the school they want. Keep special schools open.
- Encourage competitive school sports, playing fields and school trips.
- Bring back student grants and scrap student loans.
- Abolish the absurd target of 50% of young people attending university and leave it to the universities to select their students.

Health

Despite our health service being given more money, much of this has been wasted on management consultants and bureaucrats. We still have long waiting lists, postponed operations, poor cleanliness, and low staff morale. The reason is that the government tries to run the NHS centrally, in all its detail, using hundreds of performance targets and ever-changing initiatives.

UKIP Wales says

- Scrap the 22 expensive Local Health Boards and replace them with more representative local control.
- Return to the 'matron' system with a single manager responsible for all care and accommodation.
- More freedom for doctors to select treatment based on clinical need rather than performance targets.
- GP surgeries to re-open in the evenings and at weekends when working people can visit.

Immigration

Under European Union law, anyone from other EU countries can live in Britain. EU rules also govern how we deal with asylum seekers. Too many newcomers are settling here – competing for jobs and causing pressure on our schools, health services and council housing. The first responsibility of our government is towards its own people.

UKIP Wales says

- Take back control of our borders – we must know who is coming in and out.
- Our own government to determine who is allowed to stay, not the European Union.
- Give work permits only to those whose skills we need.

Crime

Our police are hamstrung by politically correct rules and form-filling. Courts can't sentence properly because prisons are full.

UKIP Wales says

- Relieve our police of unnecessary paperwork
- Ensure stricter sentencing and zero tolerance of antisocial behaviour and petty crime.
- Build more prisons urgently.
- Make police chiefs directly elected and forces accountable to local authorities.
- Defend our British legal traditions of jury trials and 'innocent until proven guilty'.

The economy

Britain can only remain prosperous and competitive in the global economy by reducing the regulatory burden and taxation on our businesses. We would cut taxes all round and pay for this by cutting government waste and halting the growth of government spending. We do not accept the argument that this means a reduction in 'front line' public services.

UKIP Wales says

- Raise the income tax threshold to £9,000 per year, taking a further 4.5 million lower paid people out of tax altogether and making everyone else better off.
- Scrap inheritance tax altogether.
- Reduce rates of company tax so our businesses can compete in the global economy.
- Slash council tax by 40%, taking it back to where it was 10 years ago, in real terms.
- Free up our businesses by scrapping thousands of unnecessary regulations.

Agriculture and fishing

As long as Britain remains in the EU, we shall also remain bound by its Common Agricultural Policy which rewards rich landowners and helps to put our farmers out of business. UKIP believes in a strong farming industry that is a reliable source of our food whilst also looking after our rural environment.

UKIP Wales says

- Replace the CAP with price support systems that recognise local conditions, such as hill farming.
- Provide financial support for young farmers.

- Return to sensible health regulations so that small local abattoirs can re-open.
- Encourage local food production and consumption.
- Take back British control over our coastal waters and rebuild our fisheries protection fleet.

Transport

Public transport needs to be more attractive and responsive to local needs, and there is gridlock on the roads. Over-zealous traffic enforcement is used merely to raise funds.

UKIP Wales says

- Improve local control and management of public transport – rail, bus and airport links.
- Rule out road pricing, oppose privatisation of parking facilities and allow free parking at hospitals.
- Remove speed cameras unless they cut accidents.
- Tax foreign lorries on the same basis as our own.

Energy

UKIP regards Britain's growing dependence on imported energy as unacceptable, yet we recognise that renewable sources such as wind power will never meet more than a small fraction of our needs. We believe that an increasing proportion of our energy must be nuclear and would also promote clean coal technology. We fully support the plan for a new barrage across the Severn.

The environment

Environmental legislation is now driven wholly by the EU – with targets for recycling that place impossible demands on our local authorities and result in large-scale shipment of our waste to China. UKIP believes strongly in protection of our environment but this must be a matter for our own government. We would vigorously defend our green belt against excessive targets for housing.

Defence

Budget cutbacks and spending on EU defence projects have left our forces overstretched and underfunded. UKIP would use our forces only where this is clearly in the national interest and ensure they are properly resourced. We would restore our traditional regiments.

Save our Post Offices

Rural post offices and the Royal Mail are being destroyed by EU rules that put limits on government support and allow private companies to cream off the most profitable business. UKIP would provide subsidies as necessary to keep post offices open.

The smoking ban

UKIP Wales regards the general ban on smoking (enforced from April 2007) as an unnecessary assault on people's freedom. We would scrap the ban, leaving pubs, restaurants and other premises to choose whether they have smoking areas or not.

Council housing

UKIP Wales will join the campaign to respect the results of ballots where council tenants say they want to keep council housing in public ownership.

The UK Independence Party

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